Afghanistan and Amritsar as a goodwill gesture. India happily complied.[63] S. Iftikhar Murshed, former Pakistani envoy to the Taliban regime, says that such meetings ensured 'greater Western sympathy for India's portrayal of Pakistan as a state sponsor [of] terrorism'.[64] India's calculation that changing US beliefs on international terrorism would bring the two countries closer was spot-on. Differences on Afghanistan between India's partisans and top US officials began to bridge the East Africa bombings. However, the US refused to publicly acknowledge Pakistan as a state-sponsor of terrorism, despite knowing the extent to which Islamabad was supporting the Taliban and other militant groups in the region.[65]

Such caution on part of the US resonated with the conciliators in India. Inderfurth, who himself was a conciliator, was convinced that the Taliban was a vehicle of Pashtun ethnic power and not just an Islamist movement. In his view, the Taliban would control most parts of Afghanistan for at least a year or even more (in 1999). The largest single ethnic group, the Pashtuns, simply would not permit non-Pashtun suzerainty over the country. But that very fact made it necessary for Pakistan to let diplomacy take over protracted military engagements, and bring the Taliban to the negotiating table. But Pakistan's rigidity in the six plus two had begun to challenge Inderfurth's patience. In a secret cable to Albright, he advocated that 'we [US] will continue our policy of trying to mitigate Taliban behavior where and when its ill-advised policies cross our path. Its policies now preclude us from offering the Taliban what it wants—recognition as the rulers of Afghanistan'.[66] The Taliban, he argued, should be recognised if, and only if, it clamps down on the terrorist networks, undertakes effective measures against the cultivation, processing, and trafficking of illicit narcotics, and improves its respect for human rights in general and treatment of women and girls in particular. For this to happen, however, the US needed to continue engaging with the Taliban and seek other levers to influence its behavior.[67] Despite his cautious conciliatory approach, Inderfurth had no doubt about the Pakistan-Taliban nexus. He had foreseen, in 1999, that if things don't change, the Taliban might just have to be treated as an enemy regime, and Afghanistan a pariah state.